CODE RED FOR INDIAN DEFENCE

Developing a strong, indigenous AI architecture is the only answer to the looming threat that Mythos-like models pose to India's sprawling defence networks

By **Pradip R. Sagar**



India's defence architecture relies on a web of software-driven communication systems, satellite networks, radar installations, air defence mechanisms and logistics chains. The emergence of advanced AI models like Anthropic's Claude Mythos introduces a new category of risk. Experts believe that in the hands of malicious actors, Mythos-like AI could scan military-grade software to uncover hidden or previously unknown vulnerabilities at a negligible cost. Unlike traditional cyber threats that depend on human expertise and take time, such AI systems can automate vulnerability discovery and exploitation at scale, drastically reducing response windows. In a worst-case scenario, adversaries can infiltrate defence networks, disrupt satellite communications, break logistics chains essential for troop movement and resource deployment as well as compromise the integrity of radar and air defence systems. All this can weaken operational preparedness; during a conflict scenario, this can prove fatal. The integration of such advanced AI into offensive cyber operations demands a fundamental shift in how India approaches strategic defence preparedness.

Jaijit Bhattacharya, president, Centre for Digital Economy Policy Research, says the main risk from models like Mythos is the short time period between identifying vulnerabilities and their subsequent exploitation, and the fact that they can discover weaknesses faster than cyber defences can repair them. Rumoured Chinese versions of Mythos, he says, could be delivered to India's adversaries and would imperil defence, telecom and energy infrastructure that are run on connected software layers.

"The same tech that can help defenders discover weaknesses and seek remedies can also help adversaries launch attacks. India needs controlled-access frameworks, mandatory AI-red team testing for defence and critical infrastructure, indigenous cyber-AI capability, and closer coordination between MeitY (ministry of electronics and information technology), CERT-In (Indian Computer Emergency Response Team), the defence ministry, DRDO (Defence Research and Development Organisation), NTRO (National Technical Research Organisation) and other sectoral regulators," says Bhattacharya.

Rohit Kumar Sharma, research analyst at the Manohar Parrikar Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses, says that since the intended use of Mythos is to secure systems, it appears to be a force for good, unless it falls into the wrong hands. He also thinks that the Mythos scare creates the condition for an AI-driven cyber arms race.

Rahul Dwivedi, founder & CEO of Pelorus Technologies, a firm that provides digital forensics and surveillance, says that the Mythos breakthrough underscores a dangerous reality: AI has tilted the balance towards offence.

With the speed asymmetry between offensive and defensive measures (which can take months), India's infrastructure—reliant on US software and Chinese hardware—is especially exposed. We

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